MR. LIFE MANAGER · FREE GUIDE

Six Meals and a Stocked Kitchen

Six meal options. Choose and cook one; build the repertoire over time.

01 Before you turn on heat

- **Choose one meal.** Read that whole procedure and check the food labels, quantities, tools and appliance instructions. Shopping or clearing an unusable kitchen comes first.
- **Gather everything.** Wash your hands, clear a clean work area and put ingredients and tools within reach. Use a can opener unless the cans have pull tabs.
- **Use ready-cooked canned beans and packaged ready-cooked rice where specified.** Dried beans or uncooked rice need different preparation and time.
- **Stay with cooking.** Keep handles out of the walking route. Do not leave active cooking to clean the kitchen or start another chore.

There is no tested finish-time promise or fixed number of repetitions to mastery. Keep the instructions handy until the particular meal feels familiar.

02 The six meals

Two servings each

Quantities are starting portions, not a nutrition prescription. Adjust for the people eating before starting. Follow the labels for preparation and storage; use optional toppings only if you already want and have them.

ONE

Pasta with tomato sauce and beans

For two: 4 ounces dry pasta; 1 cup jarred tomato pasta sauce; one 15-ounce can of ready-cooked white beans, drained; 1 cup frozen peas.

Tools: Large pot, saucepan, stove, strainer, stirring spoon, measuring cup, microwave and microwave-safe vegetable bowl, and two serving bowls.

1. Cook the peas by their package directions. Check the microwave has finished, then put the peas, sauce and drained beans in the unheated saucepan.
2. Fill the pot with the pasta package's water quantity. Bring to a boil, add pasta and set a timer for the package time. Stay with the pot and stir as directed.
3. Check the pasta is cooked, switch off its burner and drain carefully into the strainer in the sink, clear of steam. Return pasta to the pot off the heat.
4. Now heat the saucepan contents according to the sauce and bean directions, stirring. Switch off its burner, combine with pasta and divide into two bowls. Check every appliance is off and serve.

TWO

Scrambled eggs and toast

For two: 4 large eggs; 2 teaspoons butter or oil for the pan; 4 slices bread.

Tools: Bowl, fork, nonstick skillet, heat-safe spatula, stove, toaster and two plates.

1. Toast the bread following the toaster instructions, then put two slices on each plate. Check the toaster has finished before moving on.
2. Crack the eggs into the bowl and beat with the fork until combined. Wash your hands after handling raw eggs.
3. Put the butter or oil in the skillet over medium-low heat. Add the eggs. Move the setting egg gently across the pan with the spatula.
4. Continue cooking until the eggs are firm and no liquid egg remains; do not serve them wet or runny. Switch off the burner, divide onto the two plates and eat.

THREE

Rice and black-bean bowls

For two: 2 cups packaged ready-cooked rice; one 15-ounce can of ready-cooked black beans, drained; 2 cups frozen mixed vegetables; 4 tablespoons salsa.

Tools: Microwave and microwave-safe bowl or the rice package's specified equipment; saucepan, stove, spoon, strainer and two serving bowls.

1. Read the rice and vegetable directions and gather the equipment they require. Heat the ready-cooked rice exactly as its package directs.
2. Put the drained beans in the saucepan and heat according to the can directions, stirring. Add water only as the directions allow.
3. Cook the frozen vegetables using their package method. Allow its full cooking time; do not assume warming rice cooks the vegetables too.
4. Divide rice, beans and cooked vegetables between two bowls. Top each with 2 tablespoons salsa. Check every appliance is off or has finished, then serve.

FOUR

Vegetable and chickpea stir-fry

For two: 2 cups frozen stir-fry vegetables with skillet cooking directions; one 15-ounce can of ready-cooked chickpeas, drained; 2 cups packaged ready-cooked rice; 1 tablespoon cooking oil; 2 tablespoons bottled stir-fry sauce.

Tools: Skillet, stove, spoon or spatula, strainer, microwave and package-specified rice equipment, and two plates.

1. Read the vegetable, chickpea, rice and sauce directions. Prepare all ingredients before heating the skillet; heat the ready-cooked rice by its package method.
2. Cook the vegetables in the skillet with the oil using the vegetable package directions and a heat level suitable for the pan. Stir as directed; stay with the skillet.
3. Add the drained chickpeas and sauce, following their heating directions. Stir until all components are ready to serve; complete any required cooking or heating time.
4. Switch off the burner. Divide the rice between two plates and spoon the vegetable-chickpea mixture over it. Check the rice appliance has finished, then serve.

FIVE

Bean tacos

For two: One 15-ounce can of ready-cooked beans, drained; 4 medium tortillas; 4 tablespoons salsa; optional 1/2 cup grated cheese.

Tools: Saucepan, stove, spoon, strainer, tortilla-package warming equipment if needed, and two plates.

1. Gather the beans, tortillas and salsa. Read the bean and tortilla preparation directions before turning on heat.
2. Put the drained beans in the saucepan. Warm as their label directs, stirring; add a little water only if appropriate to the directions. Switch off the burner when ready.
3. Prepare or warm the tortillas according to their package using equipment you have. Divide the beans among the four tortillas, leaving room to fold.
4. Add salsa and optional cheese. Fold the tortillas around the filling, put two tacos on each plate and confirm all appliances are off. Serve.

SIX

Grilled cheese and tomato soup

For two: 4 slices bread; 4 slices melting cheese; 2 tablespoons softened butter; enough canned tomato soup for two label servings, plus water or milk only if the soup label calls for it.

Tools: Skillet, saucepan, stove, spatula, butter knife, soup spoon, two plates and two bowls.

1. Check whether the soup is ready to serve or condensed. Measure two label servings into the saucepan with any label-required water or milk. Leave the heat off while you make the sandwiches.
2. Butter one side of each bread slice. Make two sandwiches with buttered sides facing outward and two cheese slices inside each.
3. Cook the sandwiches in the skillet over medium-low heat. Check underneath with the spatula and turn when golden. Cook until the other side is golden and cheese melts; lower heat if browning too quickly. Switch off the skillet burner and put one sandwich on each plate.
4. Heat the prepared soup following the label, stirring and staying with it. Switch off the burner when ready. Divide between two bowls, keeping clear of steam. Confirm both burners are off and serve with the sandwiches.

FINISH COOKING SAFELY

Cook scrambled eggs firm, not runny. Follow food and appliance directions, and confirm heating appliances are off before sitting down. Refrigerate perishable leftovers within two hours, or within one hour if the temperature is above 90°F. Use suitable containers and follow storage directions.

Sources: FDA, What You Need to Know About Egg Safety and FoodSafety.gov, 4 Steps to Food Safety.

03 Build a pantry around what you cook

You do not need to buy supplies for all six meals. Stocking is a separate job from tonight's cooking.

- **Pick one meal you intend to make again.** Check what you already have and what equipment it needs.

- **Set a shopping budget.** List only the missing ingredients for the chosen number of servings. Check package sizes and storage space before buying.
- **Choose suitable storage.** Use food labels for pantry, refrigerator and freezer instructions. Date leftovers and check what needs using first.
- **Add another option when useful.** Pasta and sauce, canned beans, ready-cooked rice or bread can support these meals, but the right list is the one you use and can afford.

Base + **Filling** + **Vegetable** + **Flavor**

This is a planning prompt, not a universal substitution rule. A new ingredient can require a different method, equipment or cooking time. Use a suitable recipe when changing the food or method.

04 Leave a manageable cleanup

- **During active cooking, attend to the food.** Keep the work area clear without leaving a hot pan for another chore.
- **Before eating, check heat and storage.** Switch off appliances and store perishable food promptly. Put sharp tools somewhere safe.
- **After the meal, wash the used dishes and utensils.** Let hot cookware cool enough to handle and follow its care directions; do not rely on an arbitrary cleanup time.
- **Wipe the preparation surface with a suitable method.** Put tools away so the next cooking session has a usable start.

A served meal is the cooking outcome. Washed tools and a usable surface are the cleanup outcome. Neither reading the guide nor buying the ingredients completes either job.

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